CA/Browser Forum Tracker

Part 1 - Server Certificate Working Group

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About This Report

This is an experimental, AI-driven research project from SRL. SRL is independent, with no outside funding and no sponsors. This tracker is a summarized pull of the public record, kept as a coherent, concise news update. It draws on the CA/Browser Forum's own ballots, mailing lists and published documents, and on the public sources of the browser root programs. An AI model reads those sources and writes the summary, and every statement links to the source it came from. Where two sources disagree, both are reported. AI makes mistakes, so check the linked source before relying on any statement. The tracker is updated each week that the public record shows a change.

The Server Certificate Working Group writes the rules for the certificates that secure the public web. It is the busiest of the Forum's groups. Its Baseline Requirements reached version 2.3.1 on 4 October 2026, the second new version since the start of September [1].

This part covers three strands of its work. Section 1 follows the ballots and the document versions they produce. Section 2 covers domain control validation, where the next hard deadline falls in December. Section 3 covers certificate profiles and cryptography, including the shrinking validity schedule and the stalled question of post-quantum keys.

One distinction governs everything below. A ballot that passes its vote is not yet a requirement. It enters a 30-day intellectual property review, and only after that does the text publish into a numbered version. A separate effective date decides when certificate authorities must comply. This part states the stage of every ballot, because confusing those states produces confident statements about rules that bind no one yet.

1. Ballots and Document Versions

The Baseline Requirements move by ballot. Each ballot that changes the text produces a numbered version, and the Forum's revision table is the authoritative record of what is in force.

Recent Developments

Two ballots published into the Baseline Requirements in the past seven weeks. Version 2.3.0 took effect on 7 September 2026, carrying Ballot SC100 on DNSSEC clarification and consolidation [2]. SC100 had passed with 22 yes votes from certificate issuers and three from certificate consumers, with no opposition [3].

Version 2.3.1 followed on 4 October and carries Ballot SC104 [1]. SC104 turns the Authority Information Access extension in subscriber certificates from a requirement into a recommendation [4]. It passed on 3 September with 21 issuer votes and five consumer votes, from Apple, Cisco, Google, Microsoft and Mozilla, and none against [4].

Its review ended with no exclusion notices, and the working group chair announced on 4 October that it was effective that day [5]. The group's agenda for 8 October confirms that version 2.3.1 was published on 4 October [6]. The group's ballots page now lists SC104 as passed [7].

The extended validation rules moved earlier. Ballot SC102 cleared its review and was published as version 2.0.4 of the Extended Validation Guidelines, effective 13 August [8]. It removes the WHOIS and RDAP same-registrant check from EV domain revalidation and points EV reuse periods at the Baseline Requirements instead of hardcoding them [9].

A new ballot entered its discussion period on 14 October. SC105 removes the High Risk Certificate Request language from both the Baseline Requirements and the Extended Validation Guidelines [10]. Its discussion runs until 21 October, its voting dates are not set, and it is written against version 2.3.1 [10]. The concept it removes came from the Validation Subcommittee, which judged it subjective and outdated in July [11].

A proposal outside any ballot reached the list on 16 October. It would require an authority to revoke a certificate on an actionable notice that the subscriber appears on a terrorism, sanctions or war crimes list [12]. The first replies were sceptical, asking who would maintain such a list and arguing that the Baseline Requirements are the wrong home for it [12]. The proposal leans on the High Risk language that SC105 would delete, so the two discussions touch [12] [10].

Current State

The ballot with the widest reach is stuck in discussion. SC-107, proposed by Sectigo and endorsed by Google and DigiCert, would tighten certificate problem reports and define what revocation means [13]. A report would need at least a serial number or hash, plus a described violation or a revocation reason, and the authority would have 24 hours to judge it actionable [13].

The same ballot defines a certificate as revoked once its serial number appears in a revocation list or draws a revoked status response, from 15 February 2027 [13]. Its redline adds a 120-hour window to check the rest of an authority's certificates for the same fault [14]. Its discussion period was due to end on 1 October [13].

By 15 October the thread held 22 messages and no vote had been called [13]. The newest concerned limiting that 120-hour check to certificates from authorities whose keys the certificate owner controls [13]. A search on 18 October still found no voting thread [15].

Three other server ballots sit short of a vote. SC103, which would require Extended Key Usage extensions on cross-certified subordinate authorities, remains in its discussion period with no progress reported [16] [17]. SC-106, the post-quantum ballot covered in Section 3, is a numbered draft with no formal stage [16].

A draft omnibus ballot would reshape the extended validation rules. It moves the EV certificate profile from the Extended Validation Guidelines into the Baseline Requirements and turns the guidelines into a validation methods document [18]. It has no ballot number and has not changed since 29 September [18]. Version 2.0.4 remains the current Extended Validation Guidelines [8].

The group is also scoping work that has not yet reached draft text. At its 8 October call Google presented on aligning the Baseline Requirements with dedicated hierarchy expectations [6]. That

would define TLS-specific issuing authority profiles and set a future date after which chaining roots serve only TLS [6]. Google also presented on linting certificates against each authority's stated profiles [6].

A separate project, announced on 13 October, will review the revocation circumstances in Section 4.9.1.1 for gaps, overlaps and ambiguities [19]. A public question about what "promptly" means in the subscriber reporting rules was forwarded to the group on 1 October, with no proposal attached [20]. The next call is 22 October [6].

Unresolved Conflicts

The Forum's own records disagree about version 2.3.1. The requirements page lists it as current and dated 4 October [1]. The Forum's GitHub repository has no release or tag for it, and its newest tag is still 2.3.0 [21]. The requirements page is the authoritative record, and a release tag would close the gap.

2. Domain Control Validation

Domain control validation is how a certificate authority satisfies itself that the applicant controls the name being certified. The rules are converging on one goal, which is to make control of a single network path insufficient to obtain a certificate.

Recent Developments

No validation method ballot has entered any stage since September [7]. The work instead moved through drafts, guidance and one large issuer's own schedule.

A revised ACME persistent DNS method was posted to the Validation Subcommittee on 26 September [22]. Its second draft replaces the account address in the DNS record with a hash over the account's public key and metadata, as a defence against malicious proxy servers [22]. Four open issues on how that method fits Section 3.2.2.4.22 may feed a coming ballot, and they have not moved since July [22] [23].

The subcommittee is also preparing guidance on artificial intelligence in validation. A post to the subcommittee on 1 October proposed a definition separating AI from the deterministic automation already used in validation [24]. The post suggested informative guidance, perhaps as an appendix to the Baseline Requirements, with minimal normative rules such as disclosure in practice statements [24]. The model is an accounting standards note on AI in service organisation audits [24].

Its 15 October agenda added three discussions, on country code clarification, on validating reliable data sources, and on validation and revocation issues tied to sanctions enforcement [25]. No minutes have been posted since the July meeting [26].

Let's Encrypt is moving ahead of the rules on network perspectives. It announced two more remote perspectives, bringing its total to six, ahead of the Forum's requirement of five from 15 December [27]. They reach its staging environment on 27 October and production on 10 November [27].

Current State

Multi-Perspective Issuance Corroboration has been mandatory since 15 September 2025 under Ballot SC-067 [28]. It requires that domain validation and CAA checks be confirmed from network vantage points that differ by geography and topology [28]. The purpose is to defeat attacks on a single network path, such as DNS manipulation and route hijacking [28].

The requirement is arriving in steps. Version 2.3.1 requires four remote perspectives now and five from 15 December 2026 [1]. Two more validation dates follow. From 15 November 2026, a reverse address lookup must use the exact lookup name, and from 15 March 2027, processing of the CAA account and validation method parameters becomes mandatory [1].

DNSSEC rules are now consolidated. SC100 gathered rules scattered through the document into a new Section 4.2.2.2 and published in version 2.3.0 [3] [2]. It settles that DNSSEC validation may run on remote perspectives but is required only on the primary one [3].

The set of permitted methods keeps contracting. Ballot SC090, published as version 2.2.2 in November 2025, gradually sunsets the email-based and phone-based methods [29]. Reuse periods are contracting alongside validity. Validation data may be reused for 200 days on certificates issued until 15 March 2027, then 100 days until March 2029 [1].

3. Certificate Profiles and Cryptography

This section holds the change with the widest operational reach, the staged reduction of certificate lifetimes. It also holds the question the industry is waiting on, which is when post-quantum keys become permissible.

Recent Developments

The first phase of the SHA-1 sunset took effect on 15 September 2026 [30]. Authorities may no longer sign new revocation lists with SHA-1, and must revoke any unexpired subordinate certificate carrying a SHA-1 signature [30]. Within days, four authorities had incident reports open for missing that deadline, as Part 4 records [31] [32].

Let’s Encrypt chose to shorten certificates faster than the schedule requires. It announced on 7 October that its default lifetime falls from 90 days to 64 days on 10 February 2027 [33]. Reuse of a domain authorization falls from 30 days to 10 days at the same time [33].

Let’s Encrypt plans a second step in 2028, to a 45-day default lifetime and seven hours of authorization reuse [33]. Its staging environment switched to 64-day certificates on 14 October [33]. Nothing will be revoked, and clients that use the renewal information protocol need no change [33].

Current State

Ballot SC081v3 sets the Forum’s own schedule, a staged reduction of validity and data reuse periods rather than a single cutover [34]. Its first step is in force. Certificates issued from 15 March 2026 may last at most 200 days [34].

Two further steps are scheduled and not yet binding. Maximum validity falls to 100 days on 15 March 2027 and to 47 days on 15 March 2029 [34]. Version 2.3.1 carries that schedule unchanged [1].

Post-quantum signatures are still not permitted in publicly trusted TLS certificates. Ballot SC-106 would permit ML-DSA keys and signatures in all three parameter sets, in server certificates, issuing authorities, revocation lists and status responses [35]. Its text says that passing it would not require any root store to trust ML-DSA [35].

The draft requires pure post-quantum chains, so an ML-DSA key must be certified by an ML-DSA signature [35]. Mozilla and Chrome representatives objected to that restriction [36]. They also argued that the proposal reaches beyond the group's browser focus, and suggested a separate working group for other certificate consumers [35].

Amazon Trust Services is taking the ballot over from Google Trust Services, according to the 8 October agenda [6]. The hand-over has produced no new text. The draft has not changed since 31 August, and no discussion thread exists [35] [37]. SC-106 does not appear on the group's ballots page [16].

The group recorded in May that post-quantum certificates have two blocking dependencies, and only one belongs to the Forum [38]. The Baseline Requirements must permit ML-DSA, and the IETF must finish the encoding standards for post-quantum algorithms in certificates [38]. Part 6 follows the IETF side.

Unresolved Conflicts

The Forum's working groups are not moving together on post-quantum algorithms. The server group has a draft and no ballot in any formal stage [16]. The S/MIME group published post-quantum algorithms in 2025 and is drafting composite signatures, as Part 3 records.

The two groups govern different certificate profiles and need not move in step. This is a real difference in pace rather than a contradiction in the record. A discussion period for SC-106 would mark the server group's first formal step.

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